ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Nutrition for Students: Eat Well on a Small Budget

Affordable meals that support concentration, energy and health

HEALTH & WELLBEING

Health & Wellbeing

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Cheap food is not automatically bad food, and expensive food is not automatically balanced. This pack explains the basics of a balanced plate, builds affordable Nigerian meal combinations, and covers hydration, food safety and the effects of caffeine and energy drinks.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain the components of a balanced diet and their functions.
- Build affordable meals using locally available foods.
- Apply food-safety practices in hostel and shared kitchens.
- Make informed choices about caffeine, sugary drinks and supplements.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

The balanced plate

You do not need imported foods to eat well.

- Carbohydrates provide energy: rice, yam, plantain, garri, maize, potatoes.
- Proteins build and repair tissue: beans, fish, eggs, chicken, milk, groundnuts.
- Fats in moderation support hormones and vitamin absorption: vegetable oil, nuts, avocado.
- Vitamins and minerals come from vegetables and fruit; include something green or orange daily.
- Fibre supports digestion and steady energy: beans, vegetables, whole grains.
- Water is essential; aim for regular intake through the day, more in heat.

Affordable combinations

Balance is about combination, not cost.

- Beans and plantain with vegetables gives carbohydrate, protein and fibre.
- Rice with beans and a vegetable stew is cheap and filling.
- Pap with milk and groundnuts adds protein to a cheap breakfast.
- Eggs are one of the cheapest complete proteins.
- Buy staples in bulk and share with roommates to reduce unit cost.
- Reduce sugary drinks; they add cost and calories without nutrients.

> **Do not skip breakfast before exams**
> Skipping meals reduces concentration and increases irritability. Even a small protein-containing breakfast improves exam performance compared with none.

Safety and stimulants

Food poisoning can cost you a week of lectures.

- Wash hands and produce; separate raw meat from cooked food.
- Cook food thoroughly and refrigerate promptly where possible.
- Be cautious with street food that has been sitting uncovered in heat.
- Treat water carefully if the source is uncertain.
- Caffeine is not a substitute for sleep; energy drinks cause crashes.
- Supplements are not a shortcut to health and can interact with medication.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Name the three macronutrients and one function of each.

Answer: Carbohydrates for energy, proteins for growth and repair, and fats for energy storage, hormone production and vitamin absorption.

2. Give an affordable balanced meal using local foods.

Answer: Beans, plantain and vegetables with water; it provides carbohydrate, protein, fibre and micronutrients.

3. Why is skipping breakfast counterproductive before an exam?

Answer: It reduces available energy and concentration, impairing performance.

4. State two food-safety rules.

Answer: Wash hands and produce, and keep raw and cooked foods separate to prevent cross-contamination.

5. What is wrong with relying on energy drinks to study?

Answer: They provide a temporary stimulant effect followed by a crash, and disrupt sleep which is necessary for memory.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] List five affordable protein sources near you.
- [ ] Plan three balanced meals using local staples.
- [ ] Set a daily water intake target.
- [ ] Practise safe food handling for one week.
- [ ] Replace one sugary drink per day with water.
- [ ] Compare the cost of bulk versus single purchases.
- [ ] Track energy levels alongside meals for a week.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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